

CHAPTER SIX

Guilt vs. Shame

In late October, the lesson was about two words that sound a lot alike but are not the same at all.

The two words were *guilt* and *shame*.

Ms. Calloway wrote them on the board.

"Friends," she said, "today we are going to learn the most important difference between two feelings that almost everybody mixes up. If you remember nothing else from this whole year, please remember this lesson. This one matters."

She paused. The class quieted.

"Guilt is the feeling that says *I did something bad*. Guilt is about what you did. Guilt is information. Guilt is your inner sense of *I have done something that doesn't fit with my values, and I need to fix it*. Guilt is your friend. Guilt is what makes you walk back into the kitchen and tell your mom about the lie."

She wrote, underneath the word *guilt*:

GUILT – *I did a bad thing. I can fix it.*

She underlined it. Then she wrote, next to it:

SHAME – *I am a bad person. I can't fix what I am.*

"Shame is the feeling that says *I am bad*. Not *I did something bad*. *I am bad*. As a person. As a whole. Shame is not about what you did. Shame is about who you are. Shame is what tells you that the mistake is not a mistake – the mistake is proof that there is something wrong with you, deep down, that cannot be fixed."

The class was quiet.

"Friends, here is what I want you to know. Guilt and shame are not the same feeling. They are very, very different feelings, even though they feel similar in your body. Guilt has a way out — you fix it, you apologize, you change. Shame has no way out, because shame is about who you are, and you cannot change who you are by trying harder."

She paused.

"And here is the secret. Shame is always lying. Always. There is no kid in this room, in this school, in this country, in this world, who is bad as a person. There is no human being who is bad as a person. There are people who do bad things. But there is no bad person. There is just human beings, all of whom are doing bad things and good things in different mixes."

She wrote, in big letters, under the chart:

SHAME IS ALWAYS LYING.

"When you feel shame, you can know — for sure — that it is lying to you. You can listen to it for a second, the way you would listen to a kid who is upset and being unfair. You can say *I hear you. I know you are scared. But you are not telling me the truth right now.* And then you can put shame down."

"This does not mean you don't take responsibility. Guilt is for that. If you did something wrong, you fix it. You apologize. You change. That is guilt's job. Shame says you can't change because you are bad. That is the lie. Don't listen to shame. Listen to guilt."

She drew a chart.

| GUILT — useful | SHAME — lying |

|---|---|

| I did something wrong. | I am wrong as a person. |

| I can apologize. | There's no apology big enough for me. |

I can change.	I can't change who I am.
I can repair.	I am unfixable.
Listen to it. Act on it.	Notice it. Don't believe it.

Marcus, in his seat, was staring at the chart.

He thought about the homework lie. He had felt guilt about that one — *I did a bad thing*, and he had gone home and fixed it. That had been guilt. Guilt was correct. Guilt had given him useful information.

Then he thought about the other lie. The one he had been carrying for almost two years. The one about Aaliyah and the bike. The lie he told his parents about how she got the scrape on her knee.

That one was different.

That one — when he thought about it now — was not *I did a bad thing*. That one had become, somewhere along the way, *I am a bad brother*. He had been carrying *I am a bad brother* in his chest for two years.

He had not known, until this moment, sitting in Room 18 in October of third grade, that *I am a bad brother* was shame. That it was, by Ms. Calloway's definition, lying. He had been believing it the whole time.

He sat very still in his chair.

Ms. Calloway was still talking. He heard her voice but the words were going past him.

He was thinking: *what would it mean to have guilt about Aaliyah, instead of shame?*

Guilt would mean: *I did something wrong. I lied. I can fix it. I can tell the truth now. I can apologize.*

Shame had been: *I am a bad brother. I can't ever undo what I did. The thing about me as a person is broken.*

If shame was lying — if shame was always lying — then *I am a bad brother* was a lie, and had been a lie this whole time, and

he had been believing the lie and carrying it for two years.

His chest got warm.

He was not crying. He was close to crying, but not crying, not yet, not in class. He blinked a few times. He looked at his pencil. He looked at the chart on the board.

SHAME IS ALWAYS LYING.

Then Ms. Calloway said, in her gentle voice that pulled Marcus back into the room:

"I want each of you to think — privately, not out loud — of one thing in your life right now where you are confusing guilt and shame. Where you are walking around with *I am bad* when really the truth is *I did something I can fix*. You do not have to share. This is just for you to think about."

Marcus thought.

He did not have to think for very long.

The Aaliyah lie. He had been carrying *I am bad* about it. The truth was *I did something I can fix*.

He could fix it. He could fix it.

He had not known, until this moment, that fixing it was a possibility. He had thought, for two years, that the lie was a thing about him — a thing he could not get out from under. He had thought, in some quiet permanent corner of his head, *I am not the brother I wish I was. I am the brother who lied to my parents to keep myself out of trouble while my sister had a bandage on her knee.*

But the bandage was healed. Aaliyah was fine. Aaliyah did not even remember the bike anymore — she had been three.

The only person still carrying the bandage was Marcus.

And he was carrying it as *who he was*, when really, all along, it had been a thing he had done. A thing he could fix.

He could tell his parents.

He could just — tell them.

Ms. Calloway, across the room, was still talking. The other kids were writing in their journals or looking at the chart.

Marcus did something he had not done in school in a long time. He raised his hand.

"Yes, Marcus?"

"Ms. Calloway? Can I — can I talk to you for a minute after class?"

She did not pause. She did not look surprised. She just said, "Of course, sweetheart. I'll be here."

Marcus put his hand down.

He spent the rest of the lesson half-listening, half-thinking. He was a little scared. He was also a little — he had not expected this feeling — excited. Like he was on the edge of putting down something he had not realized was so heavy.

When the lesson ended and the kids started gathering their things, Marcus stayed at his table. Ms. Calloway came over.

"Hi, sweetheart. What's on your mind?"

"There is a thing I did when I was six. I lied to my parents about it. I have been carrying it for a long time."

Ms. Calloway sat down across from him. She did not push for details. She just waited.

"I think it is shame, not guilt," Marcus said. "I think I have been thinking it was a thing about me. Like *I am a bad brother*. But I think it was a thing I did. And I think I could maybe fix it. By telling my parents."

Ms. Calloway nodded.

"Marcus, that is a very, very wise thing to have figured out. I am proud of you for the thinking you just did."

"It is about my sister."

"Okay."

"She got hurt and I told my parents it was her fault, but it was — it was my fault. I was supposed to be watching her. She

fell off her bike."

"Okay. How is she now?"

"She is fine. She does not remember."

"Okay. And the part you have been carrying — what is it?"

"That I am a bad brother. That I lied to my parents to keep myself out of trouble. That my parents would be different about me if they knew."

Ms. Calloway did not jump in. She let the words sit on the table between them.

Then she said, "Marcus. Do you want to talk about this with Mr. Tate? He helped you with the Aaliyah thing in first grade, and he knows the family. You can talk to him together with me, or alone. Or you can talk to me alone right now. Or you can take some time. Whatever you want."

Marcus thought about it.

"I think I want to talk to Mr. Tate. With you there."

"Okay. I will set it up. Tomorrow, during your quiet work block. Mr. Patel will know where you are."

Marcus stood up. He felt like he was a few inches taller than he had been when he sat down.

He picked up his backpack.

"Ms. Calloway?"

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"You are welcome, Marcus. You are doing the work. I am just here to point at the chart."

She smiled. He smiled back. He left the room.

That night, he did not tell his parents anything yet. He waited until after the meeting with Mr. Tate the next day. But for the first time in two years, he went to bed and did not think about Aaliyah and the bike. He thought, instead, about the chart on the board, and the sentence on it:

SHAME IS ALWAYS LYING.

He thought it as he fell asleep. It was, by then, halfway to becoming a sentence he had memorized.

We are going to come back to Marcus's lie in Chapter Twelve. The week between today and Chapter Twelve is the most important week of Marcus's whole third-grade year. We have to give him room to walk through it.

For now, we leave him at the end of a Friday in late October, falling asleep with a sentence in his head that was, in his particular life, going to change the way he carried himself for the next thirty years.

Shame is always lying.

You can hold on to that one too. It is yours now.